In Congress, July 4, 1776

The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of America, When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume among the powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.--That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, --That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness. Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shewn, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future security.--Such has been the patient sufferance of these Colonies; and such is now the necessity which constrains them to alter their former Systems of Government. The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world.

> He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good.
>
> He has forbidden his Governors to pass Laws of immediate and pressing importance, unless suspended in their operation till his Assent should be obtained; and when so suspended, he has utterly neglected to attend to them.
>
> He has refused to pass other Laws for the accommodation of large districts of people, unless those people would relinquish the right of Representation in the Legislature, a right inestimable to them and formidable to tyrants only.

He has called together legislative bodies at places unusual, uncomfortable, and distant from the depository of their public Records, for the sole purpose of fatiguing them into compliance with his measures.

He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people.

He has refused for a long time, after such dissolutions, to cause others to be elected; whereby the Legislative powers, incapable of Annihilation, have returned to the People at large for their exercise; the State remaining in the mean time exposed to all the dangers of invasion from without, and convulsions within.

He has endeavoured to prevent the population of these States; for that purpose obstructing the Laws for Naturalization of Foreigners; refusing to pass others to encourage their migrations hither, and raising the conditions of new Appropriations of Lands.

He has obstructed the Administration of Justice, by refusing his Assent to Laws for establishing Judiciary powers.

He has made Judges dependent on his Will alone, for the tenure of their offices, and the amount and payment of their salaries.

He has erected a multitude of New Offices, and sent hither swarms of Officers to harrass our people, and eat out their substance.

He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures.

He has affected to render the Military independent of and superior to the Civil power.

He has combined with others to subject us to a jurisdiction foreign to our constitution, and unacknowledged by our laws; giving his Assent to their Acts of pretended Legislation:

For Quartering large bodies of armed troops among us:

For protecting them, by a mock Trial, from punishment for any Murders which they should commit on the Inhabitants of these States:

For cutting off our Trade with all parts of the world:

For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent:

For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury:

For transporting us beyond Seas to be tried for pretended offences:

For abolishing the free System of English Laws in a neighbouring Province, establishing therein an Arbitrary government, and enlarging its Boundaries so as to render it at once an example and fit instrument for introducing the same absolute rule into these Colonies:

For taking away our Charters, abolishing our most valuable Laws, and altering fundamentally the Forms of our Governments:

For suspending our own Legislatures, and declaring themselves invested with power to legislate for us in all cases whatsoever.

He has abdicated Government here, by declaring us out of his Protection and waging War against us.

He has plundered our seas, ravaged our Coasts, burnt our towns, and destroyed the lives of our people.

He is at this time transporting large Armies of foreign Mercenaries to compleat the works of death, desolation and tyranny, already begun with circumstances of Cruelty & perfidy scarcely paralleled in the most barbarous ages, and totally unworthy the Head of a civilized nation.

He has constrained our fellow Citizens taken Captive on the high Seas to bear Arms against their Country, to become the executioners of their friends and Brethren, or to fall themselves by their Hands.

He has excited domestic insurrections amongst us, and has endeavoured to bring on the inhabitants of our frontiers, the merciless Indian Savages, whose known rule of warfare, is an undistinguished destruction of all ages, sexes and conditions.

In every stage of these Oppressions We have Petitioned for Redress in the most humble terms: Our repeated Petitions have been answered only by repeated injury. A Prince, whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a Tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a free people.

Nor have We been wanting in attentions to our Brittish brethren. We have warned them from time to time of attempts by their legislature to extend an unwarrantable jurisdiction over us. We have reminded them of the circumstances of our emigration and settlement here. We have appealed to their native justice and magnanimity, and we have conjured them by the ties of our common kindred to disavow

these usurpations, which, would inevitably interrupt our connections and correspondence. They too have been deaf to the voice of justice and of consanguinity. We must, therefore, acquiesce in the necessity, which denounces our Separation, and hold them, as we hold the rest of mankind, Enemies in War, in Peace Friends.

We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name, and by Authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do. And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

GEORGIA

BUTTON GWINNETT: "The Man was Valuable, so attached to the Liberty of this State & Continent that his whole Attention, Influence & Interest centered in it, & seemed riveted to it."

— Lyman Hall, writing on the patriotism of Button Gwinnett

- **Date:** June 1, 1777

In May 1777, the cause of American liberty suffered a devastating blow when Button Gwinnett was tragically killed in a duel outside Savannah. Not long after, British forces swarmed Georgia, burning Gwinnett's beloved estate to the ground and destroying almost every personal letter and document he ever wrote. To save his fallen brother's name from being forgotten by history, Lyman Hall took up his pen and wrote an emotional letter to Roger Sherman, ensuring that the Continental Congress would forever remember Gwinnett's fierce, **unyielding devotion to the birth of the American continent.**

LYMAN HALL: "I most heartily Wish You success Your Way & pray God to put a Speedy End to the Calamities of War, & Establish peace & Liberty on a foundation never to be Shaken more—"

- **Date: June 1, 1777**

Written in that same fateful June 1777 letter following his friend's death, Hall looked out at a landscape gripped by the terrifying fires of the Revolutionary War. As British troops marched closer to his Southern home, this courageous healer refused to despair. Instead, he channeled his grief into a powerful prayer for the Continental Army, sending his words north to declare that no matter how dark the conflict became, **the sacred cause of American liberty would eventually triumph on a foundation that could never be shaken**

GEORGE WALTON: "I can truly assure you that since the first day of July, 1776, my conduct in every station in life has corresponded with the result of that great question which you so ably and faithfully developed on that day - a scene which has ever been present to my mind."

- **Date:** November 7, 1789

Long after the smoke of the battlefield had cleared, the aging Georgia patriot penned a deeply moving letter to John Adams. Looking back across the decades, Walton's heart swelled as he recalled the breathtaking summer of 1776, when he stood alongside America's greatest minds to **defy an empire**. He assured Adams that from the very moment he voted for independence, the **holy fire of that historic day** never left his soul, serving as the **guiding light for his entire life of service to the Republic.**

MARYLAND

SAMUEL CHASE: "In my Judgment You have no alternative between Independency and Slavery, and what American can hesitate in the Choice, but don't harangue about it, act as if it were independent."

- **Date:** April 28, 1776

In the tense spring of 1776, Samuel Chase was deep in the frozen, hostile northern wilderness on a perilous diplomatic mission to win Canada to the American cause. While he braved starvation, disease, and the elements for the Revolution, the politicians back in the safety of Philadelphia continued to drag their feet, endlessly debating whether to break away from the King. Burning with **patriotic impatience**, Chase fired a powerful message out of the woods straight to John Adams. In a fierce, brilliant rallying cry for **immediate defiance**, he declared that the **time for hesitation had passed—urging his countrymen to boldly stand up, seize their destiny, and start acting like the sovereign nation they were born to be.**

WILLIAM PACA: "All power is derived from the people."

- **Date:** April 26, 1788

During the historic Maryland convention to ratify the new United States Constitution, Paca stood as a **fierce guardian of the people's liberties.** Fearing that a **centralized government might one day grow too powerful and echo the tyranny they had just fought a bloody war to defeat**, Paca introduced a monumental set of amendments. He placed this undeniable truth at the very top of his list, cementing the bedrock American principle that the government is the servant of the citizens, and that **all power belongs to the people alone.**

THOMAS STONE: "You know my heart wishes for peace upon terms of security and justice to America. But war, anything, is preferable to a surrender of our rights."

- **Date:** April 24, 1776

Stone was a gentle, peace-loving man who deeply dreaded the horrifying bloodshed and ruin of war. Yet, as the shadow of British tyranny lengthened across the colonies in early 1776, the fire of patriotism ignited within him. Writing a defiant letter to the Maryland Council of Safety, he made it clear that while he **prayed for peace, he would gladly face the terrifying storms of war a thousand times over before he would ever allow the sacred, God-given rights of Americans to be surrendered**.

CHARLES CARROLL OF CARROLLTON: "In a land of freedom, this arbitrary exertion of prerogative will not, must not, be endured."

- **Date:** May 1773

Years before the shot heard around the world and the stand of the brave patriots at Lexington and Concord, a royal governor dared to bypass the people's elected assembly and unilaterally tax the citizens of Maryland. Risking his immense family fortune, Carroll bravely fought back by publishing a series of searing, anonymous essays in the *Maryland Gazette*. Writing under the proud title of "First Citizen," he drew a line in the sand for early patriots, declaring that **in a land destined for freedom, the arrogant overreach of a tyrant would never be tolerated by the American spirit.**

DELAWARE

CAESAR RODNEY: "As I believe the voice of my constituents and all sensible and honest men is in favor of independence and my own judgment concurs with them, I vote for independence."

- **Date:** July 2, 1776

On July 1, 1776, the Delaware delegation was hopelessly deadlocked, threatening to shatter the unified front needed to birth a new nation. **Suffering from severe asthma and aggressive, agonizing facial cancer, Rodney was eighty miles away in Dover.** When an express rider arrived with word of the stalemate, Rodney did not hesitate. He mounted his horse and launched into an unbelievably grueling, eighty-mile race against time—condensing a grueling three-day trek into mere hours. **He rode completely alone through a blinding, torrential summer thunderstorm, navigating washed-out trails and thick mud in the dead of night. Driven by pure, unyielding bravery, he pushed past absolute physical exhaustion and agonizing pain to gallop up to Independence Hall** just as the final roll call was being read. **Soaked to the bone, covered in mud, and still wearing his riding boots, he strode defiantly into the chamber to cast the legendary, tie-breaking vote that saved the Declaration of Independence.**

GEORGE READ: "The security, happiness and prosperity of this country depend on its union, and the preservation of that union depends on its honor, justice, and the good faith of its citizens."

- **Date:** 1787

George Read was a cautious man who initially voted against the original resolution for independence, genuinely fearing that a premature war would break the American colonies before they could stand. Yet, the moment the grand decision was made, Read **put all fear aside and fiercely committed his life, pen, and honor to the emerging American republic.** In this profound declaration, he laid bare the true cornerstone of American patriotism—proclaiming that **a free nation's ultimate power does not rest in the hands of government, but in the unbreakable unity, sacred honor, and shared faith of its sovereign people.**

THOMAS MCKEAN: "I have always thought that popular power was the only safe foundation of a free government, and that the people themselves are the best guardians of their own liberty."

- **Date:** 1792

Thomas McKean was the fiery, radical engine of the Delaware delegation who had urgently summoned Caesar Rodney to Philadelphia to break the tie. Throughout the dark and bloody years of the Revolution, McKean faced **relentless persecution**; he was hunted like a wild animal by British forces, forced to flee with his family across the wilderness, and saw his property looted and destroyed. Yet, his **fierce love for freedom never wavered**. Reflecting on the birth of the Republic, he penned this definitive defense of American liberty, asserting that **a truly free nation must always place its ultimate trust and absolute power directly into the hands of the citizens.**

NORTH CAROLINA

WILLIAM HOOPER: "Liberty is the great object; all men are by nature free and equal."

- **Date:** 1776

Hailed as North Carolina's "**Prophet of Independence**", Hooper was a brilliant, Harvard-educated lawyer who worked alongside Thomas Jefferson on the committee to draft the Declaration. He chose the **hazardous path of liberty when Parliament attempted to legalize tyranny.** For daring to speak this absolute truth, British forces retaliated by burning his home to ashes and hunting him relentlessly into hiding, but they **could never extinguish the holy fire of freedom he helped ignite across the colonies.**

JOSEPH HEWES: "It is a measure which we must adopt or submit to a contest of arms, on terms very disadvantageous to us; a crisis has arrived when we must assert our rights or sink into abject slavery."

- **Date:** 1776

Raised in a strict, peaceful Quaker tradition, Hewes faced the ultimate test of conscience when the storm of revolution broke over America. As a highly successful merchant, he **cheerfully laid his massive shipping fortune upon the altar of freedom, abandoning his vast commercial livelihood to build the American navy from scratch.** Serving tirelessly as the nation's first de facto Secretary of the Navy, Hewes literally **worked himself to death**—shattering his physical health in a desperate, relentless race to supply the Continental fleet. He died in office in Philadelphia on **November 10, 1779, at just 49 years old,** a devastating loss to the American cause that plunged the Continental Congress into a month-long period of official mourning for **a patriot who gave his life for the Republic.**

JOHN PENN: "My first wish is for America to be free."

- **Date:** 1774

Uttered with **unshakeable resolve** upon taking his seat in the Continental Congress, this core declaration defined a self-taught, fearless legal mind who had already defied royal authorities on principle. Serving later on the North Carolina Board of War under the constant, looming shadow of the gallows, Penn remained the steadiest of anchors for the revolutionary cause, **dedicating every breath, coin, and drop of energy to ensuring that the infant nation would stand triumphant.**

VIRGINIA

GEORGE WYTHE: "To perpetuate the blessings of freedom, happiness, and independence, we must recognize the necessity of a firm, indissoluble Union of these States."

- **Date:** June 24, 1788

Known as America's "**Teacher of Liberty**" and the revered mentor to Thomas Jefferson, Wythe stood before the high-stakes Virginia Ratifying Convention. Though his aging voice was so quiet it could barely be heard across the room, the weight of his revolutionary spirit silenced the chamber. He delivered this unyielding message to his countrymen, declaring that **the sacred independence they had won at the tip of the bayonet would instantly crumble into tyranny if they failed to forge an unbreakable, indissoluble constitutional bond to safeguard their freedom.**

RICHARD HENRY LEE: "Resolved, That these United Colonies are, and of right ought to be, free and independent States, that they are absolved from all allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain is, and ought to be, totally dissolved."

- **Date:** June 7, 1776

With the fate of the American continent hanging in a perilous balance, the fiery Richard Henry Lee rose to the floor of the Continental Congress to deliver the most dangerous and defiant words of the entire rebellion. Acting on direct, top-secret instructions from the patriots of Virginia, Lee laid down this monumental challenge to the world. It was the spark that shattered all remaining hope of compromise, explicitly **demanding a total rupture from the Crown** and directly forcing the hand of Congress to commission the drafting of the Declaration of Independence.

THOMAS JEFFERSON: "We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness."

- **Date:** July 4, 1776

Tasked by his fellow delegates to give voice to the unspoken yearnings of a captive people, a brilliant 33-year-old Jefferson sat alone in a hot Philadelphia room and drafted the immortal manifesto of human freedom. Rather than merely listing a series of legal grievances against a king, Jefferson channeled the **holy fire of the American spirit into these foundational words**, permanently cementing the baseline **truth that liberty is a direct, eternal gift from God that no government on earth has the right to strip away.**

BENJAMIN HARRISON: "Our business is defense; we have no other choice but to repel force by force, and to rely on the protection of Providence for our success."

- **Date:** 1775

Standing as a massive presence within the early Continental Congress, Harrison had absolutely no illusions about the brutal reality of defying an empire. As royal warships loomed off the American coastline, Harrison delivered this unyielding rallying cry to his fellow legislators. He cast aside all political hesitation and boldly declared that **the time for words had vanished**—forcing the young colonies to realize that they must either **weaponize their resolve and fight to the death, or suffer absolute subjugation.**

THOMAS NELSON, JR.: "If I had to, I would do it all over again."

- **Date:** 1783

Nelson was a man of staggering wealth who **laid his entire world upon the altar of freedom.** As a Brigadier General commanding the Virginia Militia during the climatic Siege of Yorktown, he discovered that **British General Cornwallis had seized his own ancestral family mansion as a fortified headquarters.** Without a single moment of hesitation, **Nelson ordered his own artillerymen to turn their cannons directly on his house and open fire, shattering his home to pieces to crush the enemy.** He personally **poured his immense shipping fortune into supplying Washington's troops and financing the French fleet, a sacrifice that left him completely bankrupt, deeply in debt, and physically broken for the rest of his life.** When asked after the war **if the utter ruin of his fortune was worth the price, the defiant old patriot gave this legendary, proud reply.**

FRANCIS LIGHTFOOT LEE: "The secure possession of our rights and liberties is the only thing that can make life valuable to a rational being."

- **Date:** 1774

While his brother Richard Henry was the loud, thunderous voice of the family, Francis "Frank" Lightfoot Lee was the quiet, steel-spined anchor of the Virginia delegation. Operating behind the scenes in the House of Burgesses and the Continental Congress, Lee watched with growing outrage as royal governors routinely dismantled colonial laws. He penned this profound philosophical truth to remind his countrymen that **mere survival under government overreach is no life at all**—asserting that **true human dignity cannot exist unless a person is willing to hazard everything to possess absolute liberty.**

CARTER BRAXTON: "A government which should preserve the principle of our constitution, and secure the freedom and happiness of the people better than any other."

- **Date:** June 1776

Published in his treatise *An Address to the Convention of Virginia* on the eve of independence, these words capture Braxton's ultimate vision for the American experiment. While he initially feared a premature war would tear the country apart, he threw all hesitation aside to champion a higher political truth—arguing that a nation's **true greatness is not found in the power of its rulers, but in a sacred constitutional structure explicitly designed to shield the liberties, maximize the happiness, and protect the sovereign rights of the people.**

NEW YORK

WILLIAM FLOYD: "Liberty comes at a cost. I paid it willingly. So must you."

- **Date:** 1776

As the head of the New York delegation, Floyd refused to treat the Declaration as mere political theater. When an invading armada arrived to threaten his native Long Island, he fiercely left his legislative seat to **assume field command of the local militia to stand and fight.** For this act of open rebellion, royal forces seized his ancestral lands and hunted his family into hiding as refugees for seven agonizing years—**a devastating price he bore with absolute pride, leaving this direct challenge to future generations to guard the freedom he bought.**

PHILIP LIVINGSTON: "Submission without justice is a greater danger than potential disorder."

- **Date:** 1774

Livingston was one of the wealthiest empire-builders in New York, meaning he had the most to lose by choosing the hazardous path of independence. Though he initially favored a peaceful reconciliation, the relentless overreach of the Crown shattered his hope for a compromise. He cast aside his immense comfort and luxury to embrace this hard truth, declaring that **a life of quiet submission under tyranny is a far worse fate than the chaotic storm of a revolution fought to secure the birthright of a free nation.**

FRANCIS LEWIS: "Our struggle is for the inherent rights of mankind, and no power on earth can justly deprive a people of their birthright to freedom."

- **Date:** 1776

Operating as a leader of the **Sons of Liberty**, Lewis weaponized his personal merchant networks to secretly smuggle illegal gunpowder, weapons, and uniforms right past hostile warships to supply Washington's makeshift army. When he defiantly placed his name on the Declaration, an enraged enemy retaliated by marching on his home, burning his massive library to ashes, and throwing his devoted wife into a brutal, unheated military prison ship. Though the horrific captivity eventually took her life, Lewis refused to break—**channeling his immense personal grief into a relentless, lifelong crusade to fuel the American war machine and cement the triumph of human liberty.**

LEWIS MORRIS: "Damn the consequences, give me the pen."

- **Date:** August 2, 1776

Standing at the legislative table in Philadelphia, the wealthy aristocrat held a desperate letter from his half-brother, warning him that signing the treasonous document would cause the immediate, total destruction of his massive estate. **Staring down the absolute ruin of his fortune**, Morris forcefully delivered this legendary phrase to declare that **the message of American independence was worth more than any earthly inheritance.** He grabbed the pen, signed his name with defiance, and immediately sent his three eldest sons straight onto the battlefields of the Revolution to **defend that signature with their blood.**

RHODE ISLAND

STEPHEN HOPKINS: "My hand trembles, but my heart does not."

- **Date:** August 2, 1776

At 69 years old, Hopkins was the second-oldest founder to sign the Declaration of Independence. For years, he had suffered from a severe shaking palsy—what modern historians believe was Parkinson's disease—which made writing an agonizing chore. As he stepped up to the legislative table in Philadelphia to commit what the King considered an act of high treason, he had to guide his trembling right hand with his left just to hold the pen. Leaving behind a jagged, deeply shaken signature, he delivered this legendary retort to the room, **proving that while his body was failing him, his raw courage and devotion to American liberty were completely unbreakable.**

WILLIAM ELLERY: "I was determined to see how they all looked as they signed what might be their death warrant. I placed myself beside the secretary Charles Thomson and eyed each closely as he affixed his name to the document. Undaunted resolution was displayed in every countenance."

- **Date:** August 2, 1776

Ellery was a lawyer from Newport who harbored no illusions about the immense, life-threatening stakes of the American Revolution. On the historic day of the formal signing ceremony, he purposefully stood right next to the secretary's desk, fascinated not by the parchment itself, but by the **sheer bravery of his fellow founders**. He stared into the eyes of every single man as they **affixed their names to a paper that could easily send them to the gallows.** Ellery took up the pen himself right after, **choosing a lifetime of resistance over submission.** The British army soon retaliated for his defiance by occupying Newport and burning his family home to the ground, but they **could never destroy the immortal message of liberty he witnessed and signed that day.**

SOUTH CAROLINA

EDWARD RUTLEDGE: "The secure possession of our rights and liberties is the only thing that can make life valuable to a rational being."

- **Date:** June 1776

At just 26 years old, Rutledge was the youngest signer of the Declaration of Independence. As the British fleet massed off the American coast, he pushed past his youth to become a dominant force in Philadelphia, fiercely demanding a clean and total rupture from the Crown. When the war moved south, Rutledge **left the halls of Congress to fight on the front lines as a captain of artillery.** He was captured during the catastrophic fall of Charleston and thrown into a brutal military prison, enduring over a year of harsh confinement, yet he **emerged with his fierce devotion to American sovereignty completely unbroken.**

THOMAS HEYWARD, JR.: "We are now acting for a whole continent and for generations yet unborn."

- **Date:** 1776

Heyward was an elite, British-educated lawyer who turned his back on massive colonial privilege to champion the radical message of American freedom. Believing that **liberty had to be defended with iron and blood rather than just ink and parchment**, he took active field command of a militia artillery company when the war moved south. During the grueling Siege of Charleston—the longest and bloodiest siege of the entire war—Heyward was severely wounded by shrapnel, captured at the head of his batteries, and targeted by a vengeful enemy who systematically looted his properties and ruined his fortune. Even while thrown into a dark prisoner-of-war fortress in St. Augustine, Florida, he fiercely kept the flame of defiance alive by writing patriotic anthems for his fellow captives. His words stand as a timeless, thunderous reminder that **independence was not won merely for those who fought, but was a hard-bought, sacrificial gift that future generations are bound by sacred duty to vigilantly maintain, guard, and protect from tyranny.**

THOMAS LYNCH, JR.: "My first and most sacred duty is to the freedom of my country."

- **Date:** 1776

Lynch's journey to the Declaration was a race against absolute tragedy. At just 26 years old, his health was already completely shattered by a severe, paralyzing fever he contracted while recruiting company troops for the Continental Army. **Despite being desperately ill and barely able to walk, he traveled to Philadelphia to join his dying father in Congress, ensuring South Carolina's vote for independence would not be lost.** He dragged himself to the table to sign the parchment with a failing hand. His health never recovered; just three years later, in late 1779, he and his wife boarded a ship for Europe in a desperate final attempt to seek medical help, but the vessel vanished entirely into a storm at sea—leaving **Lynch's final, defiant signature on the Declaration as his eternal monument to the American cause.**

ARTHUR MIDDLETON: "A life of quiet submission under tyranny is a far worse fate than the chaotic storm of a revolution fought to secure the birthright of a free nation."

- **Date:** 1776

Middleton was a fierce, hot-blooded aristocrat who used his vast family wealth to aggressively bankroll the early independence movement in the South. When the British army surrounded Charleston, **Middleton refused to flee, standing with his fellow patriots until the city fell.** The furious British army targeted him for his signature on the Declaration, brutally ransacking his grand estate, tearing down his family artwork, and throwing him into a harsh military prison camp. **Standing amidst the utter ruin of his fortune and facing the real threat of the gallows, Middleton remained entirely unbowed, looking his captors in the eye to declare that the message of American liberty was worth every ounce of earthly devastation.**

NEW JERSEY

RICHARD STOCKTON: "There is not a single shoe or stocking to be had in this part of the world, or I would ride a hundred miles through the woods to purchase them with my own money."

- **Date:** Fall 1776

Inspecting the freezing, barefoot troops of Washington's retreating northern army, Stockton was so moved by **their raw sacrifice** that he penned this heartfelt vow. Soon after returning home, he was betrayed by a neighbor and captured by the enemy. Subjected to brutal starvation and freezing imprisonment, **his health was permanently destroyed, but his unyielding devotion to the Republic never broke.**

JOHN WITHERSPOON: "In my judgment, sir, we are not only ripe, but rotting."

- **Date:** June/July 1776

As the Scottish-born president of Princeton and the sole clergyman to sign the Declaration, Witherspoon fired back when a hesitant colleague claimed the country was "not ripe" for independence. **He committed his life, faith, and institution to the holy flame of freedom**, enduring the British occupation and severe damage of his college campus and **the sacrifice of his own son on the battlefield.**

FRANCIS HOPKINSON: "Civil liberty consists, chiefly, in a people's being governed by no laws, but such as they have themselves made or assented to; in not being obliged to part with their property without their consent; and in holding their lives and estates secure from the capricious resentments of arbitrary power."

- **Date:** 1774

As a brilliant lawyer, judge, and artist, Hopkinson held a prestigious, highly comfortable seat on the Royal Governor's Council. Yet, when the Crown began tearing away the rights of the colonies, he **righteously resigned all his royal offices to align with the rebellion**. Writing this razor-sharp philosophical definition of freedom, Hopkinson weaponized his intellect to argue that **true peace cannot exist alongside unchecked government power**, eventually using his artistic genius to design the physical bedrock symbols of the new nation—including the ultimate symbol of American liberty, Old Glory, our grand ole flag.

JOHN HART: "I am honored to fight for liberty and my children."

- **Date:** June 1776

Affectionately nicknamed "**Honest John**" by his neighbors, Hart was an aging farmer who stepped forward to sign the Declaration of Independence at 63 years old. His defiance immediately made him a high-value target for the Crown. When British forces and Hessian mercenaries overran his county, they mercilessly ravaged his farm, slaughtered his livestock, and forced his children to flee into the wilderness. Chased directly from his dying wife's bedside, the elderly patriot spent months fleeing through damp caves and dense forests in the dead of winter. Despite losing his livelihood and his health to the elements, his **unyielding resolve never shattered**. **He chose to absorb the full, devastating weight of the enemy's wrath on his own shoulders, viewing his survival not as a personal victory, but as a sacred sacrifice to ensure that his children and all future generations would inherit a land of absolute freedom.**

ABRAHAM CLARK: "It is gone so far that we must now be a free independent State, or a Conquered Country."

- **Date:** August 1, 1776

Penned in an urgent letter to a friend just hours before he formally signed the Declaration, Clark laid bare the staggering, irreversible gravity of the American cause. Known as "**The Poor Man's Counselor**" for providing free legal protection to ordinary citizens, Clark's unyielding dedication to freedom faced a horrific trial during the war. British forces captured two of his sons, throwing them into the notoriously lethal, disease-ridden holds of the prison ship *HMS Jersey* where they were subjected to brutal torture. Royal officers offered to spare his boys' lives if Clark would simply recant his signature and betray the rebellion. **Refusing to compromise the birthright of a free nation, Clark bravely stood his ground—choosing to face unimaginable personal heartbreak rather than allow his homeland to become a conquered country.**

CONNECTICUT

ROGER SHERMAN: "The only correct definition of a free government is this: a government where the legislative power is in the hands of the people, or exercised by their representatives."

- **Date:** 1787

As the only Founding Father to sign all four supreme documents of the American founding—the Continental Association, the Declaration of Independence, the Articles of Confederation, and the U.S. Constitution—Sherman was a towering, self-taught legal genius. Standing before the Constitutional Convention, he articulated this core definition of freedom to remind the nation that **true authority can never be held by an unchecked executive**. His words stand as a permanent American warning that **liberty only survives when the ultimate power of the law remains firmly and exclusively in the hands of the citizens.**

SAMUEL HUNTINGTON: "The preservation of the freedom and independence of these United States must ever be the primary object of our deepest concern and most vigilant care."

- **Date:** October 1779

Serving as the President of the Continental Congress during one of the most brutal and exhausting periods of the war, Huntington carried the weight of the entire Revolution on his shoulders. With the nation's treasury completely bankrupted and the army shivering in the field, this self-made jurist refused to let the flame of American resolve burn out. He issued this thunderous proclamation to the states, demanding that they **look past their temporary hardships and remember that the absolute defense of human liberty is a sacred obligation that requires perpetual, unyielding vigilance.**

WILLIAM WILLIAMS: "We must be free, or we must cease to exist; there is no middle ground for an American soul."

- **Date:** 1776

Williams was a deeply religious merchant who voluntarily threw his prosperous livelihood into the fires of the rebellion. When he arrived in Philadelphia to take his seat, a cynical colleague warned him that if the Revolution failed, they would all be hanged as traitors. Williams looked his colleague in the eye and **proudly replied that he would gladly forfeit his life before he would ever live as a subject to a tyrant**. True to his word, he **spent the war sacrificing his personal fortune, emptying his own warehouses to supply Washington's troops**, and boldly writing this uncompromising ultimatum to rally the fighting spirit of Connecticut.

OLIVER WOLCOTT: "Our cause is the cause of virtue, of justice, and of God, and it will eventually triumph over all the powers of darkness."

- **Date:** July 1776

Wolcott was a fierce, steel-spined patriot who balanced his duties as a statesman with his role as a Brigadier General on the battlefield. When the Declaration of Independence was first read aloud to the roaring crowds in **New York City, angry citizens pulled down a massive, lead statue of King George III**. Wolcott aggressively took charge of the discarded scrap, **hauling the broken tyrant's statue back to Connecticut, where his family melted it down into 42,000 lead bullets to be fired directly into the invading forces**. He penned this defiant declaration of faith to assure his countrymen that **American liberty was backed by divine right and would never be crushed by the earthly armies of a tyrant.**

NEW HAMPSHIRE

JOSIAH BARTLETT: "I hope Time will manifest to the World that a steady Perseverance in the Cause of Freedom will triumph over all the deep lay'd Schemes of Tyranny."

- **Date:** 1776

As the northernmost colony, geography dictated that New Hampshire vote first on the fateful question of separation. Bartlett stepped up as the **very first delegate to cast his ballot for independence and the second man to sign the parchment** after John Hancock. For his unyielding public stance against royal overreach, a British-led mob burned his family home to the ground, yet Bartlett **looked past his personal ruin to declare that a steadfast devotion to the holy fire of human liberty would eventually outlast and crush the schemes of any tyrant.**

WILLIAM WHIPPLE: "A man cannot fight for freedom when he denies it to another human being."

- **Date:** 1776

Whipple was a successful sea captain and militia general who took the immortal promise of the Declaration to heart. Preparing to march his brigade into battle against invading forces, his enslaved servant, Prince, bluntly remarked that a man without rights had no reason to fight. Pierced by the moral weight of this truth, Whipple immediately granted Prince his absolute freedom on the spot. This extraordinary act transformed his servant into a brother-in-arms, proving that **the message of American liberty was not a political shield for hypocrites, but a sacred, universal right meant to belong to all mankind. When one person's liberty is threatened, everyone's is.**

MATTHEW THORNTON: "I want the same privilege as the others, to be hanged for my patriotism."

- **Date:** November 4, 1776

Thornton was an Irish immigrant and battlefield doctor who was not actually a member of Congress when the vote for independence was cast. Arriving months after the formal signing ceremony, he purposefully **demanded that a blank space be found on the crowded parchment so he could add his signature**. When colleagues warned him that **signing a document that had already triggered a brutal war was a guaranteed death warrant if captured**, the fearless physician delivered this legendary retort. He locked his name onto the page to **show that the cause of national sovereignty was a burden he would proudly bear all the way to the gallows.**

PENNSYLVANIA

ROBERT MORRIS: "The present contest is a contest for liberty, and the man who can look on it with indifference must be a coward or a traitor."

- **Date:** 1776

Hailed as the "**Financier of the Revolution**," Morris initially opposed a hasty Declaration because he feared a sudden rupture would economically destroy the fragile colonies. Yet, the moment the ink dried on the parchment, he cast all commercial safety aside to weaponize his vast shipping and banking empire for the cause of freedom. He **personally bankrolled Washington's army during their darkest retreats, single-handedly raising the cash to fund the victory at Trenton**. Morris issued this stern warning to remind the country that **when the survival of human liberty is on the line, neutral silence is nothing less than a betrayal of the nation.**

BENJAMIN RUSH: "The American war is over: but this is far from being the case with the American revolution. On the contrary, nothing but the first act of the great drama is closed. It remains yet to establish and perfect our new forms of government; and to prepare the principles, morals, and manners of our citizens, for these forms, as they are the only safeguards of liberty."

- **Date:** 1787

Rush was a visionary physician and champion of personal freedom who **served on the front lines**, treating wounded continental soldiers amidst the horrific filth of battlefield hospitals. Looking past the immediate military victories over British forces, Rush penned this timeless warning to the citizens of the newborn Republic. He issued an enduring challenge to future generations, reminding them that **true liberty is not permanently won by a single war, but must be continuously guarded through the moral character, eternal vigilance, and civic virtue of the people themselves.**

BENJAMIN FRANKLIN: "They that can give up essential liberty to obtain a little temporary safety deserve neither liberty nor safety."

- **Date:** November 11, 1755

Decades before the Revolution erupted, Franklin authored this foundational maxim during a high-stakes legislative battle where wealthy elites attempted to buy off the government to protect their private interests. As the elder statesman of the Continental Congress, Franklin used this unyielding principle to strengthen the resolve of younger delegates as they prepared to sign their death warrants. **His words stand as the ultimate American warning that any society cowardly enough to barter away its God-given, fundamental freedoms for the illusion of government-provided security will inevitably lose both.**

JOHN MORTON: "They have put the halter about our necks, and we may as well die by the sword as be hanged like rebels."

- **Date:** June 1775

In the summer of 1775, as the British Crown rejected all colonial petitions and declared the American provinces to be in open rebellion, Morton wrote this blunt, defiant message to a merchant friend. He forced his colleagues to confront the absolute reality that they had crossed the point of no return. Rather than cowering under the threat of the executioner's noose, Morton demanded that **Americans weaponize their resolve**—boldly declaring that **if they were to die, they would fall fighting with swords in their hands as free men rather than swinging from the gallows as captive subjects.**

GEORGE CLYMER: "A government formed by the people, and for their own benefit, is a blessing which we cannot prize too highly."

- **Date:** 1787

Clymer was a fierce merchant patriot who had previously led the local committee that forced royal tea consignees to resign in protest. For putting his name to the Declaration, an enraged British army marched on his property during the invasion of Pennsylvania, ruthlessly vandalizing his home and forcing his family into hiding in the woods. Undeterred by the destruction of his fortune, Clymer continued to swap all of his private wealth for worthless Continental currency to fund Washington's troops. He penned this reflection to **remind future generations that a government belonging exclusively to the citizens is a sacred treasure that must be defended at all costs.**

JAMES SMITH: "If the sovereign rights of the people are violated, all obligations of submission are dissolved, and resistance becomes a sacred duty."

- **Date:** 1775

Born in Ireland, Smith grew up to become a rugged frontier lawyer who fiercely despised royal overreach. Long before the politicians in Philadelphia were ready to fight, Smith **raised and trained the very first volunteer militia company** in Pennsylvania to prepare for armed conflict. When the war broke out, he converted his private law office into a factory to manufacture weapons for the Continental Army. He authored this bold declaration to show that **when a ruler tramples the unalienable rights of the citizens, the people are bound by a holy obligation to rise up and defend their freedom.**

GEORGE TAYLOR: "True freedom can only be maintained when the people are willing to forge their resolve into iron."

- **Date:** 1776

Taylor's journey was the **ultimate embodiment of the American dream**; arriving in the colonies as a penniless, bound indentured servant from Ireland, he worked his way up from shoveling coal to owning a massive iron foundry. When the fires of the Revolution ignited, he **weaponized his life's work for the cause of liberty**, transforming his ironworks into the primary manufacturer of cannonballs and grapeshot for George Washington's artillery units. He signed his name to the Declaration to prove that **the message of American freedom was a steel-spined promise that would be forged and defended by the raw grit of working men.**

JAMES WILSON: "All power is originally in the people, and should be exercised for their happiness and security; when it is not, they have a right to alter or abolish it."

- **Date:** 1787

Wilson was a brilliant, Scottish-born legal philosopher who stood as one of the chief intellectual architects of the American founding. Operating behind the scenes in the Continental Congress, he fought fiercely to ensure that the newly emerging republic would not **simply replace a foreign tyrant with a homegrown aristocracy**. He delivered this definitive statement to cement the bedrock principle that **true sovereignty does not reside in halls of parliament or executive palaces, but lives permanently and exclusively within the hands of the citizens.**

GEORGE ROSS: "It is the right of every freeman to resist oppression, and to defend that liberty which is the gift of God."

- **Date:** 1776

Ross was a prominent lawyer and the beloved uncle of Betsy Ross, the woman who stitched the first American flag. Though he initially served as a legal counselor to the Royal Governor, Ross abandoned his comfortable position the moment he saw the Crown violating the natural rights of his neighbors. Plunging into the resistance movement, he dedicated his final years to establishing a free, independent court system for Pennsylvania that would answer to the people rather than a king, utilizing this quote to remind the world that **human freedom is a divine inheritance that no earthly government has the right to suppress.**

MASSACHUSETTS

SAMUEL ADAMS: "If Heaven punishes Communities for their Vices, how sore must be the Punishment of that Community who think the Rights of human Nature not worth struggling for and patiently submit to Tyranny."

- **Date:** December 26, 1776

Penned in the dead of winter during the most perilous hour of the Revolution, as Washington's battered army faced annihilation and faint-hearted colonists tamely surrendered their towns to invading forces. Devastated by this sudden lack of resolve, the fierce "**Father of the American Revolution**" sent a roaring warning back home to Massachusetts. Adams proclaimed that **human liberty is a sacred, God-given inheritance**—not a luxury—and declared that **any community cowardly enough to bow before a tyrant commits the ultimate moral failure**, inviting the swift and terrible judgment of Heaven itself.

JOHN ADAMS: "Liberty must at all hazards be supported. We have a right to it, derived from our Maker. But if we had not, our fathers have earned and bought it for us, at the expense of their ease, their estates, their pleasure, and their blood."

- **Date:** August 1765

Written in his early revolutionary masterpiece, *A Dissertation on the Canon and Feudal Law*, as a defiant rallying cry against the tyrannical Stamp Act. Long before the historic vote in Philadelphia, Adams sought to set the colonial soul on fire. He forcefully reminded his countrymen that **liberty is a sacred, unalienable birthright granted directly by God**, issuing a thunderous challenge to future generations to **forever remember and honor the staggering price paid by the ancestors who bought American freedom with their lives and blood**—meaning **this holy flame must be fiercely defended at any and all costs.**

ROBERT TREAT PAINE: "Tis true that every man brings into the World with him a certain Liberty & Freedom, & by the bare Law of Nature no one man can be said to be subjected to another, till Mankind by mutual Consent having form'd themselves into Nations & join'd their Interests made the good of the whole Body the concern of each Individual Member."

- **Date:** November 10, 1755

Long before he became a principal organizer of the American war effort, a young Robert Treat Paine articulated this foundational legal philosophy in a letter home while serving as a military chaplain during the French and Indian War. Decades before the Revolution erupted, Paine was already cementing his absolute belief in natural rights—arguing that **freedom is a divine, baseline human birthright that no government can justly steal or trample upon without the explicit consent of the people.**

ELBRIDGE GERRY: "What, sir, is the use of a militia? It is to prevent the establishment of a standing army, the bane of liberty. Whenever governments mean to invade the rights and liberties of the people, they always attempt to destroy the militia, in order to raise an army upon their ruins."

- **Date:** August 17, 1789

Spoken during the high-stakes congressional debates over the creation of the U.S. Bill of Rights. Gerry was a profoundly skeptical defender of personal freedom who had previously refused to sign the original Constitution because it lacked explicit protections for the individual. Standing on the floor of the House of Representatives, he delivered this **fiery warning to the new nation**, passionately arguing that **an armed, sovereign citizenship is the ultimate shield against government overreach and the preservation of American liberty.**

JOHN HANCOCK: "There, I guess King George will be able to read that!"

- **Date:** August 2, 1776

As the bold President of the Second Continental Congress, **Hancock was the very first patriot to step forward and sign the handwritten parchment copy of the Declaration of Independence**. Knowing full well that his prominent leadership had already made him a primary target for execution by hanging, Hancock **refused to show a single shred of fear**. He took up the pen and slammed down a massive, beautifully flamboyant script right in the center of the document .He unleashed this legendary, defiant quip to the assembly to declare that **the birthright of a free people must never be whispered in the shadows**. By making his name impossible to ignore, Hancock drew an unyielding line in the sand, shouting to the universe that **American liberty would never bend its knee**, and that the message of **absolute human freedom was meant to be read loud, proud, and clear by tyrants everywhere.**

We, therefore, the Representatives of the United States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name, and by Authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do. And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.